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Peking May 25th

No. Wades

No. 131.

Confidential

—o—

Rec. Aug. 3

—o—

The Japanese Ambassador.

Visit to & conversation with.

Objects of his Embassy.

In the Legation

Sept 3rd

Received

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Pekin
May 25. 1873.

No 131

Confidential

My Lord,

The Japanese Ambassador Soyesima Tanaomi having left his card at the Legation, I called on him on the 20th Instant.

As I stated, in my Despatch No 120 of the 15th Instant, he had at first been disposed to expect the visits of Foreign Representatives. This was manifestly in consequence of advice which has since been tempered, for he is a very quiet unassuming man with no outward sign

of

he,

Earl Granville. K.G.

&c &c &c

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of the capacity to be looked
for in a man occupying
so high a post as that of foreign
Secretary to his own Government.

He handed me a letter
from Mr. Watson requesting that
I would assist him in furthering
the objects of his Mission which
had been confidentially
communicated to Mr. Watson. To
ask him, therefore, in what way
I could be of use to him was
in effect to ask him what these
objects were. He said he had
come to exchange ratifications
of the Treaty which was accomplished

to

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to deliver a Letter from the Mikado to the Emperor of China, and to obtain satisfaction for the murder of certain Lewchewans who were ship-wrecked upon the coast of Formosa. The last question had not yet been approached. On the second, he had as yet received no answer. He asked what way we had made in regard to it?

I told him how we stood and how vain it was in China to look for any speedy termination of any discussion.

Coming to the ceremonial I said that I thought, were

the

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the Audience refused, foreign Governments should not fail to notice the affront; but that if it were conceded on terms not derogatory to the dignity of foreign nations, I was, as I had been throughout, the advocate of every concession that would lessen the difficulties of the Chinese in a course to them so novel.

The Ambassador said that my remark bore out what had been told him regarding the interest I felt in the Chinese. He was aware that

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that I was very familiar with their ways of thought, and had been informed that I was much consulted by them.

This I could not affirm. The Chinese did some times consult me, but rarely followed my counsels, whether given spontaneously or otherwise.

He paped on to the Formosa question. I did not like to ask him plainly whether Japan, as I have heard, contemplates annexation of the island, and nothing he said to me would justify the apsumption. I have

Good

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good reason for all that to
believe that it's annexation
will be attempted. If it be,
China is powerless, materially,
to prevent it.

Soyesima asked me
if we had not had reason to
complain of the ill-treatment
of ship-wrecked sailors on
Formosa. I said that in 1842,
during the first war, the crew
of the "Nerbudda" was massacred,
and when the Treaty of Nanking
was signed we stipulated that
the authorities responsible should
be

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be punished. There had of
later times been outrages to
complain of, but the compact
made with the coast savages by
M. Legendre (the former Consul
-General of the United States
and now attached to Soysima's
Embassy,) had undoubtedly done
good. Various crews of late
had owed their safety to this
agreement.

I am not sure what
remark on either side occasioned
an allusion to the inability
of the Chinese to control these
savages: but I referred the
Ambassador to the Chinese map
with

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with which he could not fail
to be acquainted as evidence
of the limits of Chinese jurisdiction
The map in question virtually
ignores the East Coast. He
showed himself perfectly familiar
with the Map we were speaking
of.

I have since heard that
this fact, the assertion of Chinese
rule over but half of the Island,
had already been spoken of by
the Japanese as justifying their
assumption of the duty of chastising
the savage Formosans. They, the
Japanese, dispute the title of
China to regard herself as Sovereign

of

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of Lewchews. The redress of the wrongs of Lewchewans therefore devolves on the Japanese. Can the Chinese punish the savage Formosans? The Japanese will probably maintain that they cannot - Japan is therefore to send a force, it may be through the Chinese Ports of Formosa to inflict the necessary punishment.

This is the sum of what I gather from the conversation of Japanese with foreigners. The Chinese are without doubt in fear of a humiliation they could not avert, and anxious to conciliate by conceding the

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the Audience or anything else they could concede without losing face.

The Japanese are also suspected of a design on Corea, and this may account for the extraordinary prevenance of Monsieur Plancy's towards them. I think he is trying, at the same time, to make good terms with them for the Chinese, the price of the bargain being of course some settlement of the Turkestan Question.

I have seen M. Legendre but once; a clever, active man; I should think, a thorough-paced adventurer, and, notwithstanding his

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his ability, with sufficient of French
pretentiousness and restlessness to
make him an unsafe adviser.

I have the honor to be
with the highest respect,
My Lord,
Your Lordship's most obedient
Humble Servant,

Thomas Francis Wade -